

You know AI matters. The hard part is knowing where to start.

An FDE works inside your business to identify the first problem worth solving, then builds a system people will use and outcomes you can measure.



AI can now execute real work

Until recently, every step required a person.

Agents can read documents, retrieve data, use tools, and carry a task through multiple steps. People step in when judgment or approval is required.

HOW THE OPERATING MODEL CHANGES

- Agents handle repeatable execution.
 - People set goals, exercise judgment, and review results.
 - One manager can supervise multiple agents.
 - Working knowledge becomes reusable workflows and Skills.
 - Microsoft's 2025 Work Trend Index describes an Agent Boss as an employee who builds, delegates to, and manages agents.
 - OpenAI defines agents as systems that complete workflows on a user's behalf, not just answer questions.
 - Google describes enterprise agents as models connected to company data, tools, memory, orchestration, and runtime infrastructure.
 - Anthropic's research suggests that people decide what work should be done, while agents increasingly decide how to execute it.
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How well a company works with agents will increasingly shape its operating efficiency.

The shift is already underway

81%

Microsoft's 2025 Work Trend Index surveyed 31,000 employees across 31 countries. Among leaders surveyed, 81% expected agents to enter their AI strategy within 12-18 months.

Microsoft · 2025

1M+

OpenAI reported more than one million business customers in 2025.

OpenAI · 2025

108x

Since February, weekly active Codex users grew 108x in legal, 41x in sales, 41x in recruiting, and 26x in marketing.

OpenAI · 2026

PUBLIC EXAMPLES IN PRODUCTION

Cisco:

OpenAI reports that Codex cut code review time by 50%, with some projects moving from weeks to days.

Carlyle:

Its multi-agent due diligence framework reportedly cut development time by more than 50% and improved agent accuracy by 30%.

TELUS:

A Google Cloud customer story reports \$53.9 million in annual savings, 87% faster issue resolution, and proactive AI resolution for 30% of calls.

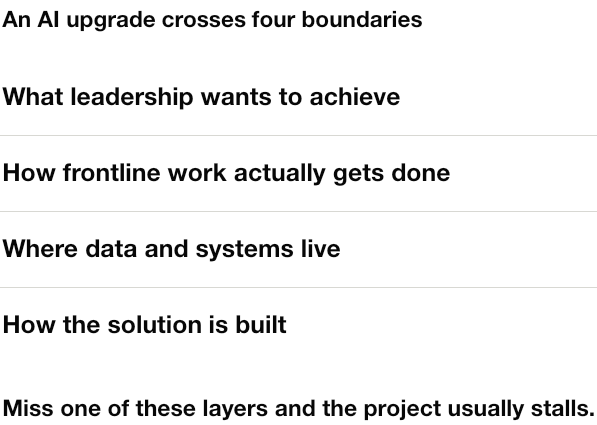
Lowe's:

OpenAI reports that Lowe's provides AI project guidance to associates in more than 1,700 stores.

Most companies want the gains from AI. Few know where to begin.

WHY EARLY AI EFFORTS STALL

- Employees have AI subscriptions but use them sporadically.
- A demo impressed people, but no one used it after launch.
- Case studies from other companies do not match how the business actually works.
- Every department has ideas. No one has a way to prioritize them.
- Knowledge is scattered across chats, spreadsheets, PDFs, shared drives, and personal devices.
- Leaders are unsure where security boundaries and agent authority should sit.



WHY INTERNAL AI PROJECTS STALL

Start with leadership only	The ambition is clear; the first practical use case is not.
Start with frontline teams only	You collect requests, but cannot tell which one deserves investment.
Start with a software vendor	Vendors need clear requirements, which is often what the company lacks.
Buy an off-the-shelf product	Deployment is fast; the workflow may not fit.
Build a platform first	Time and budget are committed before business value is proven.

The missing role connects business reality, product decisions, and implementation. That is the FDE.

An FDE starts with ambiguity and stays until the result can be tested

A Forward Deployed Engineer is not simply a developer working on-site.

The work begins inside the business: what leadership needs, how employees work, where the data lives, and where delays, errors, or handoffs cause problems.

Once the problem is clear, the FDE selects the right way to solve it:

- Use an existing product if it already solves the problem.

- Build a Skill when that is enough.

- Integrate existing systems when the workflow spans multiple tools.

- Create a database or knowledge base when data needs to be structured first.

- Design the handoff between people and agents when the workflow is suitable.

From a focused tool to an enterprise-wide AI program

One focused problem

- Company-specific Skills
- Document, spreadsheet, and image processing
- Quotation, data entry, reconciliation, and reporting automation
- Small custom SaaS applications

Best when the problem is clear and results are needed quickly.

One business workflow

- Discovery interviews and workflow mapping
- Role-specific agents
- Integrations across ERP, CRM, collaboration, and messaging tools
- Exception handling and human approval
- Progress, outcome, and activity logs

Best when work crosses teams and systems through manual handoffs.

A data foundation

- Operational databases
- Enterprise knowledge bases
- Data cleanup and consistent naming
- Permissions and access boundaries
- Trusted data for agents

Best when information is difficult to find, share, or trust.

An enterprise-wide AI program

- Identify work suitable for AI across departments
- Redesign how people and agents divide the work
- Define permissions, approvals, and accountability
- Set the pilot sequence and expansion plan
- Train the company's Agent Bosses

Best when leadership wants one coordinated program.

Diagnose first.

Build only what is worth building.

1. Define the business objective: save time, reduce errors, increase revenue, or change how work gets done.

2. Observe the spreadsheets, files, messages, and systems employees actually use, including exceptions outside the official process.

3. Rank opportunities by value, difficulty, data readiness, risk, and time to validation. Some problems do not need AI.

4. Choose one job. Agree on the owner, data, scope, and success metric before building the first usable version.

5. Once real users have tried it, decide whether to improve it, expand it, or stop.

A pilot should produce evidence, not just a demo.

Depending on scope, a pilot may include:

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|--|---|
| — A map of the current workflow | — A defined problem and pilot boundary |
| — A working prototype or system | — The data and permissions it uses |
| — Clear responsibilities for people and agents | — Human approval points |
| — A before-and-after comparison method | — A recommendation to continue, adjust, or stop |

BEFORE WORK BEGINS, WE AGREE ON

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|------------------------------|---------------------------------|
| — Who owns the outcome | — What completion means |
| — What is outside this pilot | — How the result will be judged |

Show the business change, not just the system

FDE PROJECT WORK | Working systems for commerce and manufacturing

GLOBAL INDUSTRIAL MANUFACTURERS



The brands above come from public company materials for industry reference; they do not imply an FDE client or partner relationship. Company names are omitted from the cases below.

CASE 1 | CROSS-BORDER E-COMMERCE

Before

Operators pulled product details from supplier spreadsheets, chat messages, and image folders. They translated, normalized, and re-entered each listing across multiple marketplaces.

What we found

The bottleneck was incomplete attributes, conflicting source files, and repeated manual checks against marketplace rules, not the copy itself.

What we delivered

We built a product-data hub and listing workflow. Agents organize, translate, and validate listings against marketplace rules; operators handle exceptions and approve publication.

What changed

- Scattered files became one product workflow
- Manual data entry became exception review
- Checks moved from after publication to before release
- Business impact: a more consistent listing cadence

CASE 2 | FURNITURE MANUFACTURING

Orders arrived through chat, spreadsheets, and drawings. We structured dimensions, fabrics, hardware, and process data; connected orders, BOMs, and work orders; and flagged missing or conflicting information before production.

Managers need a new skill: leading agents

FDE delivery builds the company's AI systems.

After launch, managers and employees need to know how to:

- Set clear goals and completion criteria

- Decide which work to delegate

- Review both the process and the result

Agent Boss training builds that capability.

The course focuses on managing work shared by humans and agents, rather than prompt writing or a tour of AI tools.

- Handle exceptions, request changes, or stop a task

- Manage data, tools, and permissions

- Turn working practices into shared Skills

- Stay accountable for business outcomes

AgentBoss School is open source

**github.com/ElliottYip/agentboss-school
MIT · v0.7.1**

Start with the right first problem

During the event, we offer a complimentary enterprise AI assessment.

YOU WILL LEAVE WITH

- One to three areas to examine first

- An initial view on whether AI fits the work

- The data, systems, and people required

- A recommendation to buy software, build a Skill, create custom SaaS, organize the data, or redesign the workflow

- A candid view on whether a pilot is worthwhile

WE MAY ALSO RECOMMEND

- The problem does not need AI

- The data is not ready

- Fix the workflow before building

- An existing product offers better value

The assessment is not a full implementation plan and does not require access to unauthorized sensitive data.

Where should your company start with AI?



ADD ME ON FEISHU AND SEND:

1. Company and industry

2. The area you most want to improve

3. How the work is done today

4. Who owns the process

5. When you would like to talk

ADD ME ON FEISHU TO RESERVE A SESSION

Start with one problem you can define, solve, and measure.